A FREE WORKBOOK FROM BREAKING INVISIBLE CEILINGS

BREAK YOUR INVISIBLE CEILING



The ARISE Workbook

Five steps to name the ceiling that's holding you back, find where it came from, and start breaking it this week.

A	R	I	S	E
ACKNOWLEDGE	REFLECT	IDENTIFY	SHIFT	ELEVATE

ASHAR SALEEM

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Consultant · Speaker

BREAKING INVISIBLE CEILINGS
Ashar Saleem

Fill it in on screen by clicking any box, or **print it** and write by hand. Either way, nobody sees this but you.

BEFORE YOU START

A note from Ashar



Fifteen years ago, I was living in a basement with my wife and kids, and I was convinced this was the best it could get for someone like me. I believed the people at the top, the CEOs and the founders, were a different kind of person.

I was completely wrong. I was hitting one ceiling after another, just like you probably are. I just didn't have a name for it.

WHAT IS AN INVISIBLE CEILING?

An Invisible Ceiling is a self-imposed limitation that defines how far you believe you are allowed to go.

This workbook walks you through **ARISE**, the five-step framework I've been building for years to help capable people find the ceiling holding them back and start breaking it. These are the same steps I walk my clients through.

Ashar Saleem

How to use this workbook

1. **Work on one ceiling at a time.** You probably have more than one, and that's normal. Start with the one that bothers you most.
2. **Give yourself 30 to 45 quiet minutes.** Phone away, door closed if you can.
3. **Be brutally honest.** Nobody sees this but you, so there's no point writing the polished version.
4. **Go in order.** Each step builds on the one before it.
5. **Do the Shift step this week.** Not someday. The workbook only works if you move.

THE ARISE FRAMEWORK

A 5-Step System for Breaking Through Invisible Ceilings

For capable professionals who are ready to stop being overlooked and ready to start being recognised.

What is ARISE?

ARISE is the core methodology behind the Invisible Ceilings framework. It is a practical, step-by-step system that helps capable professionals identify the self-imposed limitations holding them back and permanently break through them. It works because it addresses the root cause, not just the symptom.

A

ACKNOWLEDGE

Admit that something is holding you back.

The first and most important step. Most capable people know something feels off. They are working hard, delivering results, and still not moving forward. ARISE begins with the courage to stop explaining it away and simply say: there is a ceiling here. We are not blaming anyone or making any excuses. Just honest recognition that a limit exists.

Ask yourself: What have I been avoiding admitting to myself?

R

REFLECT

Be brutally honest about where it came from.

Invisible ceilings do not appear overnight. They are built over time, through past experiences, environments, relationships, and survival patterns that once served a purpose. Reflection is the process of tracing the ceiling back to its origin, to understand it rather than to assign blame. A ceiling you understand loses half its power immediately.

Ask yourself: When did I first start believing this about myself?

I

IDENTIFY

Name the specific ceiling. Make it concrete.

Vague ceilings are unbeatable. A ceiling you can name is a ceiling you can break. This step moves the work from feeling to fact. From 'something is holding me back' to 'this specific pattern in this specific situation is the ceiling.' Naming it precisely is what makes everything that follows possible.

Ask yourself: If I had to name my ceiling in one sentence, what would it be?

S

SHIFT

Take one small deliberate action toward change.

This step is about identifying the smallest possible move that creates momentum. The ceiling was built through repeated small actions. It is broken the same way. Just start a conversation, set one boundary because movement breaks the pattern.

Ask yourself: What is the smallest action I could take today that the ceiling says I shouldn't?

E

ELEVATE

Rise above the ceiling. Permanently.

Breaking through once is not enough. The ceiling will attempt to rebuild itself, through old habits, familiar environments, and the voices of people who knew the previous version of you. Elevate is the commitment to building the habits, mindset, and environment that make the ceiling structurally impossible to return. This is where capability becomes identity.

Ask yourself: What does the version of me who has broken through this ceiling look like every day?

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You Were Built for More. Act Like It.

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A

STEP 1 OF 5

ACKNOWLEDGE

Admit that something is holding you back.

A R I S E

This is the hardest step, and it's the most important one. You've lived with this ceiling for so long that it feels like part of you, and when something becomes part of you, you protect it. We're not blaming anyone or making excuses here. This is just honest recognition.

Tick anything that sounds like you.

- ☐ Everyone relies on me, but I'm not the one who gets chosen.
- ☐ I keep my best ideas to myself in meetings.
- ☐ I wait to be noticed instead of speaking up.
- ☐ I know I'm capable of more than I'm doing.
- ☐ I've been in the same place for years and can't say why.
- ☐ I tell myself my work will speak for itself.
- ☐ I say "that's just how I am" more than I'd like to.
- ☐ I avoid asking for what I actually want.

1 Where in your life do you feel stuck right now?

Think beyond work too: your career, relationships, confidence and the people around you.

2 What have you been avoiding admitting to yourself?

3 What excuse do you use most often? Write it exactly the way you say it.

An excuse is often just a ceiling with better vocabulary.

4 Finish this sentence: "Something is holding me back, and it shows up most when..."

R

STEP 2 OF 5

REFLECT

Be brutally honest about where it came from.

A R I S E

Ceilings don't appear overnight. They're built over years, through what happened to you, what people told you and the places you grew up in. Now trace this one back to where it started. You're not looking for someone to blame. You're looking to understand it, because a ceiling you understand loses half its power.

FROM ASHAR

When I was a kid, I solved problems my own way and got the right answer, and my teachers still marked it wrong because I didn't use the book's method. Nobody asked me why. They labelled me disobedient and distracted instead, and I carried that label for decades before I even noticed it.

1. **When did you first start believing this about yourself? How old were you, and where were you?**

2. **Did someone give you a label? A teacher, a parent, a boss or a friend. What exactly did they say or call you?**

3. **Back then, what did this belief protect you from?**

4. **Is it still true today? What evidence do you have that it isn't?**

I

IDENTIFY

Name the specific ceiling. Make it concrete.

Vague ceilings are unbeatable. "I'm a quiet person" gives you nothing to work with. Your ceiling needs to be one complete sentence that says what you do, when you do it and the fear behind it. That's a ceiling with an address, and once it has an address, you can find your way to it.

TOO VAGUE	A CEILING WITH AN ADDRESS
"I'm a quiet person."	**"I stay quiet in meetings because I'm afraid people won't listen to me."**
"I'm not leadership material."	**"I don't apply for senior roles because I believe people like me don't get chosen."**
"I'm just scared."	**"I avoid asking for a raise because I'm afraid of hearing no."**

Build your sentence

I (what I do or avoid) _____

when (the situation) _____

because I'm afraid that (the fear) _____

MY CEILING IN ONE SENTENCE

_____

_____

_____

Read it out loud. How does it feel to see it written down?

_____

_____

_____

S

STEP 4 OF 5

SHIFT

Take one small deliberate action toward change.

This step is about identifying the smallest possible move that creates momentum. The ceiling was built through repeated small actions, and it's broken the same way. You don't need a big transformation. Just start a conversation, or set one boundary, because movement breaks the pattern.

> **DON'T DO THIS ONE ALONE**
>
> You can acknowledge, reflect and identify sitting alone with your thoughts. Shift is the step where you may need someone else. Pick one person you trust and say, "Can you give me five minutes? I'm trying to make a change, and I want to start with you."

1 What's the smallest action you could take this week that your ceiling says you shouldn't?

2 Who is your safe person to start with?

3 When exactly will you do it?

4 What will you say? Write your first sentence.

Your 7-day Shift tracker

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		

STEP 5 OF 5

E

ELEVATE

Rise above the ceiling. Permanently.

Breaking the ceiling isn't the win. Keeping it broken is. Ceilings try to sneak back in, sometimes after a few days and sometimes after years. Most of the time they come back through the people around you, because they're used to the previous version of you. Elevate is where you set the standards that keep it out.

1 **Who or what is most likely to pull you back to the old version of you?**

2 **What will you do the moment you notice the ceiling coming back?**

3 **What is one standard you're setting for yourself from today?**

4 **What does the version of you who has broken through this ceiling look like every day?**

MY COMMITMENT

I've named my ceiling, and I'm choosing to break it. I'll take small steps, I'll ask for help when I need it, and when the ceiling tries to come back, I'll start again.

SIGNATURE

DATE

PUT IT ALL TOGETHER

My Ceiling on One Page

Copy your answers here, then screenshot or print this page and keep it where you'll see it every day.

A

ACKNOWLEDGE · THE CEILING I'M ACKNOWLEDGING

R

REFLECT · WHERE IT CAME FROM

I

IDENTIFY · MY CEILING IN ONE SENTENCE

S

SHIFT · THE SMALL STEP I'M TAKING THIS WEEK

E

ELEVATE · THE STANDARD I'M KEEPING

I'll come back to this page on: _____ *(30 days from today works well)*

WHAT'S NEXT

You just named your ceiling.

Most people go their whole lives without doing what you just did. Breaking one ceiling usually shows you the next one, and that's normal. That's how growth works. You only lose when you give up.

TAKE THE FREE INVISIBLE CEILING AUDIT

Find out which of the four ceiling patterns you're living under, and where your biggest blindspot is.

breakinginvisibleceilings.com

READ THE BOOK

Invisible Ceilings: Stop Being Reliable. Start Being Influential. An Amazon No.1 Bestseller in Canada.

Available on Amazon

WATCH AND FOLLOW

New videos every week on breaking the ceilings that keep capable people stuck.

YouTube @LeadwithAshar · Instagram @asharsaleemofficial

WANT HELP BREAKING IT?

Send me the sentence you wrote on the Identify page. I read every message, and I'll tell you where I'd start.

hello@breakinginvisibleceilings.com

I see you. And together, we can fix it.

Ashar Saleem